

Halloween: What It Really Is

Why Followers of Yahshua Stay Clear of It in Every Form

An Unholy Days Study

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible with the divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Scripture never uses the word Halloween. But it speaks clearly to everything Halloween is built on: a night about the dead, spirits, and reaching into the unseen, later dressed in a church name and a tradition of praying for the dead.

YHWH did not only tell His people not to worship the gods of the nations. He told them not to learn how the nations worshipped and then do it to Him. That one instruction settles the question, trunk-or-treat included.

SECTION I

Where It Started: Samhain

Long before the church was involved, the Gaelic people of Ireland and Scotland kept a festival called Samhain (pronounced SOW-in) around November 1. It marked the end of summer and the start of the dark half of the year. The people believed that on that night the wall between the living and the spirit world grew thin, and that spirits and the dead walked the earth.

So they lit bonfires, left food and drink out to appease those spirits, and practiced divination to see what the coming year would bring. Most of what we know comes from medieval Irish writings, but the picture they give is consistent: at its root, this was a night about death, spirits, and the unseen.

There shall not be found with you anyone who makes his son or his daughter to pass through the fire, one who uses divination, one who practices sorcery, or an enchanter, or a sorcerer, or a charmer, or a consulter with a familiar spirit, or a wizard, or a necromancer. For whoever does these things is an abomination to YHWH.

DEUTERONOMY 18:10-12

SECTION II

Rome Put a Name On It

The church did not remove the pagan night. It built on top of it. Historians debate whether Rome chose the date on purpose to absorb Samhain, but the result was the same: a church feast about the dead laid over a night already about the dead.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
Pre-Christian	Samhain kept around November 1 in Ireland and Scotland: bonfires, offerings to spirits, divination.
700s	Pope Gregory III dedicates a chapel in Rome to all the saints on November 1.
About 835	Gregory IV makes All Saints' Day a feast for the whole church.
About 1000	All Souls' Day spreads on November 2, a day for praying the dead out of purgatory.
Name	The night before becomes All Hallows' Eve, shortened to Halloween.

He said to them, "Full well do you reject the commandment of Elohim, that you may keep your tradition... making void the word of Elohim by your tradition, which you have handed down. You do many things like this."

MARK 7:9, 13

SECTION III

The Customs and Their Roots

Every familiar Halloween custom grew out of that mix of pagan and Roman belief about the dead.

CUSTOM	WHERE IT CAME FROM
Going door to door	"Souling": the poor asked for soul cakes and promised to pray for the household's dead in return.
Costumes	"Guising": wearing disguises on a night believed to be full of wandering spirits.
Jack-o'-lanterns	Carved turnips in Ireland and Scotland, which became pumpkins once the custom reached America.
Trick-or-treat	Spread across the United States in the early 1900s, drawing on the older door-to-door customs.
Today	Samhain is one of the eight sabbats of modern witchcraft, and the Satanic Bible lists Halloween as one of its major holidays.

SECTION IV

The Lie at the Center

Put the pagan layer and the Roman layer side by side and the same idea sits underneath both: the dead are active, wandering, and reachable. Samhain said the dead cross over and walk among us. All Souls said the dead are waiting on our prayers. Scripture says the opposite.

For the living know that they will die, but the dead don't know anything, neither do they have any more a reward; for their memory is forgotten.

ECCLESIASTES 9:5

His spirit departs, and he returns to the earth. In that very day, his thoughts perish.

PSALM 146:4

As the cloud is consumed and vanishes away, so he who goes down to Sheol shall come up no more. He shall return no more to his house, neither shall his place know him any more.

JOB 7:9-10

When they tell you, "Consult with those who have familiar spirits and with the wizards, who chirp and who mutter:" shouldn't a people consult with their Elohim? Should they consult the dead on behalf of the living?

ISAIAH 8:19

Isaiah answers his own question in the next verse by sending the people back to the instructions and the testimony (Isaiah 8:20). If the dead are not roaming, then whatever wants you to believe they are is not your loved one. Yahshua took on flesh so that through death He might bring to nothing the one who had the power of death (Hebrews 2:14). We do not celebrate the lie He came to destroy.

SECTION V

You Shall Not Do So to YHWH

Right before Israel entered the land, YHWH told them exactly what to do with the worship practices of the nations they were replacing.

Be careful that you are not ensnared to follow them, after that they are destroyed from before you; and that you not inquire after their gods, saying, "How do these nations serve their gods? I will do likewise." You shall not do so to YHWH your Elohim; for every abomination to YHWH, which he hates, they have done to their gods.

DEUTERONOMY 12:30-31

Whatever thing I command you, that you shall observe to do. You shall not add to it, nor take away from it.

DEUTERONOMY 12:32

Notice what He forbade. Not only the worship of other gods, but borrowing their way of worship and pointing it at Him. The rest of Scripture says the same thing.

Don't learn the way of the nations, and don't be dismayed at the signs of the sky; for the nations are dismayed at them.

JEREMIAH 10:2

You shall not walk in the customs of the nation, which I am casting out before you: for they did all these things, and therefore I abhorred them.

LEVITICUS 20:23

SECTION VI

Why Trunk-or-Treat Is Still Halloween

Many churches believe they have solved the problem by moving the night to the parking lot. But it is the same night, the same costumes, and the same candy, with a Bible verse taped to the trunk. Scripture shows again and again that putting YHWH's name on a borrowed practice does not make it holy.

When Aaron saw this, he built an altar before it; and Aaron made a proclamation, and said, "Tomorrow shall be a feast to YHWH."

EXODUS 32:5

For because you didn't carry it at first, YHWH our Elohim broke out in anger against us, because we didn't seek him according to the ordinance.

1 CHRONICLES 15:13

David had the right goal when he moved the ark on a new cart the way the Philistines had (2 Samuel 6), and Uzzah died. Nadab and Abihu were sincere when they offered fire YHWH had not commanded (Leviticus 10:1-2). He has always cared how we come to Him, not only that we come.

Have no fellowship with the unfruitful deeds of darkness, but rather even reprove them.

EPHESIANS 5:11

Don't be unequally yoked with unbelievers, for what fellowship have righteousness and iniquity? Or what fellowship has light with darkness?

2 CORINTHIANS 6:14

WITNESSING OR COPYING?

Exposing darkness is witnessing. Copying it is not. When Paul stood among the idols in Athens, he reasoned with the people and preached the resurrection, but he never joined their rites to do it (Acts 17:22-31). The church keeping the date, the costumes, and the candy is not exposing Halloween. It is keeping Halloween.

SECTION VII

Answering the Pushback

WHAT YOU WILL HEAR	WHAT SCRIPTURE SAYS
"Don't judge me over days" (Romans 14:5-6, Colossians 2:16)	Those passages deal with disputes among believers, not taking part in practices rooted in the dead and spirits. Halloween falls under Deuteronomy 12:30-31.
"Paul said eat the meat from the market" (1 Corinthians 10:25-27)	Keep reading. Once someone tells you it was offered to idols, don't eat it (1 Corinthians 10:28). Halloween's origin is no secret.
"The name is Christian: All Hallows"	All Saints and All Souls are built on praying for and to the dead, which Scripture never teaches (Ecclesiastes 9:5). The name makes the case stronger, not weaker.
"We're just using it to witness"	YHWH said don't do it to Him (Deuteronomy 12:31). Aaron's calf had His name on it too (Exodus 32:5).
"It's just fun for the kids"	You can't drink the cup of Adonai and the cup of demons (1 Corinthians 10:21). Give them something better instead of something borrowed.

SECTION VIII

Keeping It True

The case against Halloween stands on solid history and plain Scripture. Some claims that circulate every October do not hold up, and using them only hands the other side an easy win. We leave these out:

CLAIM	WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS
"Samhain was the Celtic god of the dead"	No evidence. Samhain is the name of the festival and month. The "god" idea came from writers in the 1700s and 1800s.
"Druids sacrificed people on October 31, and trick-or-treat came from their demands"	No historical source supports this.
"Jack-o'-lanterns were lit with human fat"	No historical source supports this.
"It is Satanism's highest holy day"	The Satanic Bible ranks a person's own birthday highest and lists Halloween as a major holiday.

Scripture never names Halloween, and we will not pretend it does. What it does name is every thing Halloween is built on, and that is enough.

SECTION IX

What to Do Instead

But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for Elohim's own possession, that you may proclaim the excellence of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.

1 PETER 2:9

If you have kept Halloween for years, this is not about condemnation. Yahshua is not taking something good away from you. Light does not need to borrow anything from darkness. Spend that night in the Word, worship with your family, and pray over your neighborhood. Let your house be the one that is different.

Come out of her, my people, that you have no participation in her sins, and that you don't receive of her plagues.

REVELATION 18:4

CROSS REFERENCE INDEX

Scripture for Further Study

THEME	REFERENCES
Customs of the nations	Deuteronomy 12:29-32; Jeremiah 10:2; Leviticus 18:3; Leviticus 20:23; Exodus 23:13
Spirits, mediums, the dead	Deuteronomy 18:9-12; Leviticus 19:31; Leviticus 20:6; Isaiah 8:19-20
The state of the dead	Ecclesiastes 9:5-6; Psalm 146:4; Job 7:9-10; Hebrews 2:14
Borrowed worship	Exodus 32:5; 2 Samuel 6; 1 Chronicles 15:13; Leviticus 10:1-2
Separation from darkness	Ephesians 5:11; 2 Corinthians 6:14-17; 1 Corinthians 10:20-21; Revelation 18:4
Traditions of men	Mark 7:9, 13; Colossians 2:8
Walking in light	1 Peter 2:9; Romans 12:2; Isaiah 5:20

Notes

Walk in truth. Walk in Light. Shalom.